

primary source of credit card debt accumulation. Couples overspend on vacations each year using credit cards to supplement their budgets. Quite often, the previous year's debt is not paid off before vacation time comes again. As the debts pile up, there is a greater tendency to want to "get away from it all."

There are some cost-saving alternatives available. For instance, if you want to go to Disney World, make contact with a church in the Orlando area. See if there is a couple in that area that would like to trade homes with you during your vacation time.

Another idea is to do volunteer work with a church in the area where you would like to vacation. Often they will provide a week of free housing for a week of volunteer work. There are many ideas if you're willing to look for them. The certainty is, God always has an alternative to debt. Once you have committed yourselves to living within the means God has provided, it opens all kinds of opportunities to experience His blessings in practical ways, like vacations. As Jesus said, "If you then, being evil, know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more shall your Father who is in heaven give what is good to those who ask Him!" (Matthew 7:11) I have witnessed this in the lives of many couples over the years as they learned to trust God.

Mike and Jan were in for help with their finances. They had experienced a string of what most of us would call bad luck. In reality, these are often the trials that God allows to come into our lives to teach us where our real source of help is.

For the previous four years, they had been trying to take a vacation trip through the West. Their children were growing up rapidly and Mike felt that one long trip would allow them to share some lasting memories. But each summer something happened. One year their house caught on fire and required extensive repairs, which drained their finances. The next year Jan's mom became very ill, which necessitated a trip north. The next year it was a car that drove right through their bedroom wall and demolished both their bedroom and their